

Memorial Day Massacre 2011

May 28st to 30th, 2011 (Originally planned as May 28th to 31st)

Shepherds Pass above Independence, CA

Full Pictures:

Shepherd Pass <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157626853969770/>

Olancho <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157626729773637/>

This was to be the second annual Memorial Day Massacre. In 2010 I led a Memorial Day weekend trip to the Southern Sierra in what was originally intended to be a big bang 3 day 7 peak extravaganza.



Due to a variety of factors things didn't go quite as planned. Jen Blackie (on her first trip of many trips with me) and I ended up making 4 peaks while the rest of the group made only one before bugging out early on the last day due to lack of water and exhaustion.

To say it will long be remembered by all participants would not be an understatement.

After the fact I'd started referring to the trip as the Memorial Day Massacre. So, of course, once Memorial Day weekend rolled around this year I was looking to continue the tradition.

After some initial poking around I decided on the Williamson area. In addition to being the second highest peak in California a 10 mile slog up Shepherds Pass put us in position for 4 or 5 different SPS peaks over a planned 4 days. Perfect!

Of last year's participants only Jen was up for round 2. Joining us was James Barlow, another repeat offender eager to run amok for several days at altitude. We had a few other strong maybes that ended up dropping out last minute.

So that left the three of us driving up in two separate vehicles. The initial altitude gain was rather steep, 6,000 ft to 11,000 ft, so I'd arranged to fly back from Boise Friday morning allowing us to get to the trailhead early for a change and take advantage of what little extra acclimatization we could manage.

Then my flight was delayed, the luggage system broke down, and I had a slight issue connecting with my ride home from the airport.

So much for an early start.

Instead we left around 3 pm, got caught in heavy traffic through LA, and arrived at the trailhead around 10 pm. We found several vehicles there and a familiar voice emerging from a lone sleeping bag turned out to be James.

Jen and I quickly sacked out.

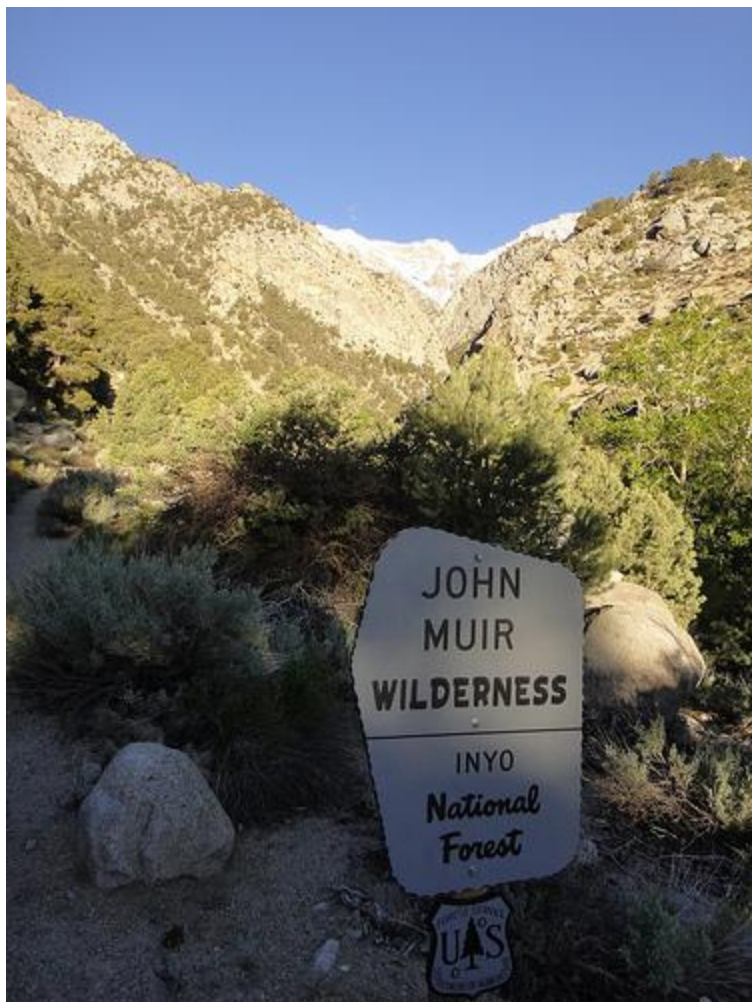
The next morning we crawled out of our bags at sunrise and went about getting our packs ready.



Interestingly enough there is a pit toilet at the Shepherds Pass trailhead. It is however missing a door and there's no roof but on the plus side it keeps the smell down.

Jen was of course ready long before James and I but eventually the three of us started up the trail.





We had three stream crossings, all flowing strongly but passable. I did manage to inadvertently dunk my boots in one of them and Jen just tromped through the stream with her usual distain for the elements.







Shepherds Pass was a decent climb though there's the usual set of switchbacks that seem to take forever to get to the point. The view was beautiful however.



Eventually we made a ridge and could see over towards Williamson.



At this point we also got a look at the feature which makes Shepherds Pass infamous. For some reason partway through climbing up to the pass at 12k ft whoever made the trail decided it would be just lovely to descend 500 of those hard won feet and then immediately regain them just for grins. (My theory is that it was done by society hating prison labor.)

We stomped through that and soon reached the first significant amount of snow at Mahogany Flats around 9k. This saved following switchbacks and we could just shortcut up the slope.



The snow was spotty but completely covered the trail in places. I started eying potential camp spots not long after but by the time we reached Anvil Camp around 10k most of the flat spots were under the snow.



We used one of these bare spots to eat lunch and Jen and James made themselves comfortable.



After that it was a mix of snow and rock with the snow covering pretty much every potential camp spot.



We reached The Pothole at 11k and with one person really feeling the altitude and increasing winds we decided to make camp.



We poked around trying to find a protected spot to set up our tents. James found a rock that somewhat protect his bivy but Jen and I had less luck with my three season tarp tent. While I'd managed 40-50 mph winds the last forecast I'd pulled at the trailhead had us being hit by 70+ mph. At the moment they were strong and increasing significantly.

There were two other folks camped up there who had related how bad the winds had been the previous night. They had tents tucked into the most protected spots I could find and had them tied down every

which way. They also planned to head up to Williamson also but had rerouted to the local Mt Keith as it was somewhat more protected from the wind.

I soon had to admit defeat with my tent. So Plan B, we were forced to drop back to a lower altitude and hope to find better protection.



So still in high spirits but somewhat bummed to give up altitude we started back down.



While it looks clear in the pictures the wind was hitting so hard by now we had to constantly watch our footing. I was flung to the ground down twice while wearing my full pack and one of them resulted in me losing my altimeter which I never did find.



And we had to worry about postholing. Jen was the lightest of the three of us and yet sunk down to her waist.

Back down around 10k just above Anvil Camp we came to a spot we'd eyed on the way up. It was somewhat more protected than 11k site but the wind was still increasing. However descending any further would put us much too far from the pass.

We found a bush that offered protection on three sides and again tried to set up my tent.



It took Jen and I several attempts before we could get everything tied down but finally it appeared we were in business. Just then a particularly brutal gust hit us and the side ripped open.

Damnit.

It was clear any attempts at putting up the tent would just result in more damage so Jen and I resolved just to sleep out.



(The plastic bag was to try and warm my feet up a bit. My bag isn't the warmest and didn't keep out the wind entirely.)

James cooked his dinner while Jen and I stuck to cold food. I had my alcohol stove along but with the unpredictable winds there was no way I could keep the lit fuel from going flying and starting a worse problem. So I settled for cold food and an ample portion of the homemade brownies Jen had brought.



James looking quite pleased with himself with his extra thick down jacket, bivy, and -20 degree bag. He did say if I was completely freezing to wake him and he'd swap bags with me.

Jen and I amused ourselves talking for a few hours then eventually went to sleep.

I woke up hours later feeling a bit of ice hit my face. It didn't seem to be much so I went back to sleep.



Ah bugger. Not long after it was really coming down. Jen estimates we were hit with about 3 inches that night.



Seeing a bit of snow accumulating on our bags we decided to pull the tattered remains of my tent over us and duck underneath. It was just like when you're a little kid and you pretend that you're camping in the mountains in the middle of a snow / windstorm. Except we were actually in the middle of a snow / windstorm.



We survived the night and even my somewhat less than overly warm 0 degree bag (that I swear each trip I'm going to replace) I managed.



This was the scene in the morning. Not being taunt the single wall material wasn't waterproof so we had moisture all over everything.

Still, we slept surprisingly well.



We had a late wakeup as we needed things to dry out before we could consider our options.



We had two people stumble on to us early that morning and exclaim at how Jen and I had spent the night. They'd camped down at Mahogany to try and avoid the weather and were going to try and push to Tyndal. We wished them luck but looking at the peaks above us I didn't think much of their chances.



Where we were the winds weren't nearly as bad as yesterday but we could see evidence of high winds on the nearby peaks.

The weather also looked somewhat variable so we decided to hunker down for a bit and see how things went. We threw our bags out on the rocks and passed the time with insightful pondering on the meaning of life, the universe, and everything.



Unfortunately the trend was towards the worse.



The snow on the ground melted only to be replaced by more.

The two who headed up the pass that morning came back a few hours later saying they'd bailed off Tyndal due to high winds and nasty clouds incoming.



In addition the two who had stayed camped at 11k soon came down. I was feeling bad enough about my tent and altimeter but they had a much worse story.

Apparently one of their tie downs had snapped and a particularly strong gust of wind had sent the tent flying up in the air. They'd lost a sleeping bag, pad, a pair of boots, and several other items. And on top of that they had about \$3k worth of photography equipment damaged. Ouch!

They'd each brought light and heavy boots so fortunately they were able to fit him with a mismatched pair in order to make it out. We promised to keep a lookout for the missing gear and they continued down.



We waited until mid afternoon but then finally called it. At points we almost dried out our sleeping bags but the weather just wouldn't cooperate and I didn't care to try and bivy on a potentially worse (lower temperature) night.

So we decided it was time to hike out.



No sign of the lost gear and we had snow flurries coming down for much of the descent.





Looking back up at Williamson it was clear the summit was being hammered.



We popped out at the trailhead several hours before dark. Down at 6k the weather was fine!

That left us out two days early. James decided he was going to head back to LA and do Baldy and Gorgonio Monday and Tuesday. Jen and I weren't quite ready to head back to the vile cesspit that is LA so decided to stay at least through Monday. We relocated to the Independence Subway and started looking at our options.

We settled on doing a day hike of Olancho which was further south therefore would hopefully avoid the worse of the weather. So after we said goodbye to James we drove down to the Sage Flats trailhead and slept for the night.

(Interesting note, there's a abandoned building at Sage Flats that looks creepy as hell when you come upon it in the middle of the night!)

Monday

I must have been having a delayed reaction from the previous night because even sleeping inside my vehicle in my only slightly soggy zero degree bag I was cold despite the fact that it was only in the low 30s.

I must be getting soft in my old age.

We woke with the sun and went about getting ready. Which basically meant Jen was ready in 5 minutes and had to wait for my slow rear end.

Since we were just dayhiking we had a much lighter load on our backs.



I was very much enjoying the lighter pack and set a grueling pace up the trail to the pass that Jen had a hard time matching.







We crossed Olancha Pass and dropped into the rather pretty Summit Meadow. I was hopeful for seeing a bear or two but sadly we only found birds and small critters.



There's a rather elaborate cow camp up there complete with tables, an old bear box, fire pit, a public corral, and more.



Continuing on we climbed up and soon could see Olancho off in the distance.



We had some snow on the trail but nothing we couldn't kickstep over. We continued down the trail until we were almost directly below the summit then started a rather abrupt 1600 ft climb.



The climb was awesome. Lots of boulders but they were large and stable. It was one of the more pleasant scrambles in recent memory.

After a good climb we popped out up top.



Being the highest point in the southern Sierra Olancha is used as a radio relay to allow the east side folks to chat with Kennedy Meadows and beyond. There's a fair amount of antennas with solar cells scattered around the southern side.





There's also an old school Sierra Club register box from the 50s. I love finding these.



There was a cold wind but otherwise the weather was spectacular.



The view south.

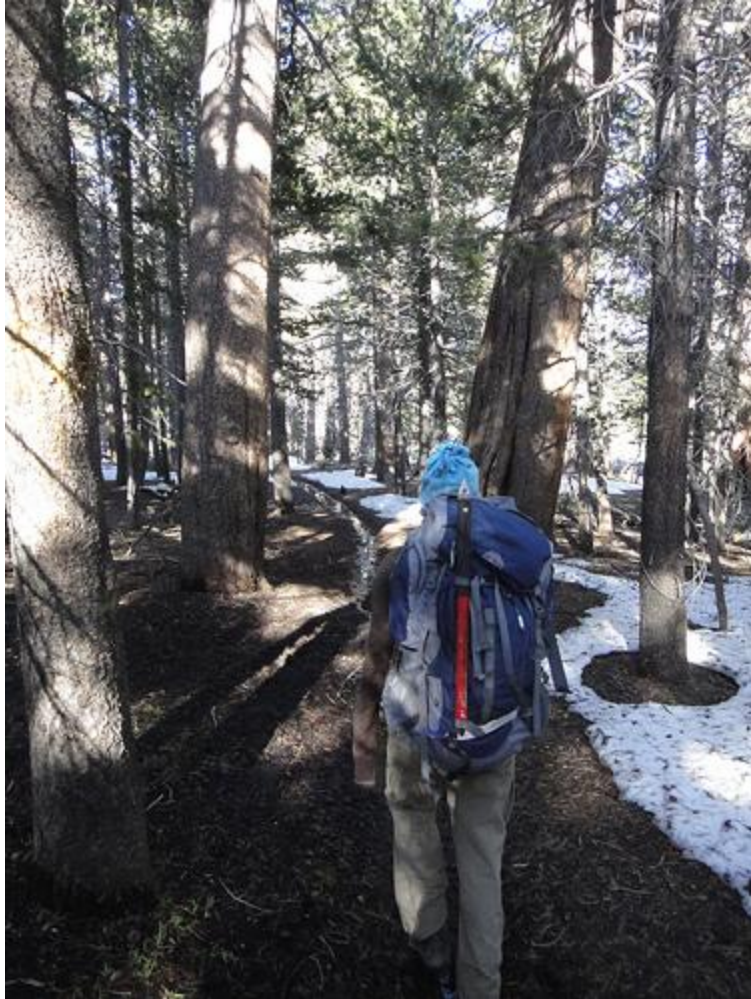


Whitney, Langley, Russell, and others to the north.



The view back down towards Kennedy Meadows.

We stayed on the summit for an hour until we were both shivering uncontrollably then reluctantly started the 12 mile trek back to the cars.



Again I hoped for bears but had to settle for a set of tracks running down the trail the same direction we were headed. One was rather large and there was at least one smaller set. I started remarking out loud about how the tracks appeared to be made by hungry bears and how they always ate the smaller member of the party but Jen was unappreciative.



We crossed back over Olancho Pass without any pigtail eating bears appearing. Ah well, maybe next time.



There was a peak further to the south that looked rather inviting. I later found out it was called Round Mountain and resolved to climb it just for grins.



We arrived back at the cars right before dark. My GPS put the stats at about 24 miles and 6,500 ft of gain, not bad.

The drive home felt much longer than it should have considering the how far south we were. Blame being tired.

So what was it for the second annual Memorial Day Massacre. Peakwise we did much worse and the broken and lost equipment was a bummer but hey, it was an adventure.

Next week: I help lead what apparently is the hardest trip done by the Hundred Peak Section in 15+ years.